from an Englishman's standpoint'.[3] It was his intellectual curiosity that transformed him into an interpreter of India to the world.

Described as the 'founding architect'[4] of India's foreign policy, Nehru was deemed unique among his contemporaries for his keen interest in global affairs. Nehru was the principal Congress personality speaking on foreign policy beginning in 1922. Indian National Congress resolutions and statements on international affairs often reflected his views. After becoming prime minister, Nehru once remarked that he was attracted to premiership because he could then allocate to himself the external affairs portfolio.[5]

Nehru had travelled extensively well before his rise to pre-eminence within the independence movement. On some occasions, the Congress took advantage of his personal travel to seek representation at international forums. In 1927, Nehru represented the Congress at the League Against Imperialism in Palais D'Egmont at Brussels. Two years later, he positioned himself as an internationalist when, as president of the Congress, Nehru stated that India could not afford to ignore what was happening in the world around her. 'We have our problems, difficult and intricate, and we cannot run away from them and take shelter in the wider problems that affect the world but if we ignore the world, we do so at our peril,' he argued.[6]

During the 1930s because of his wife Kamala's convalescence – and later death – at a sanatorium in Lausanne, Switzerland, Nehru spent considerable time in Europe. This enabled him to build relationships in England, Spain, Czechoslovakia, Poland, Hungary and even the United States. Nehru later travelled to countries that were still under colonial rule. Trips to Indonesia (formerly Dutch East Indies), Morocco, Algeria (formerly French North Africa), and Egypt enabled Nehru to build close ties with individuals who later played key roles and came to power in their countries. He also visited Turkey, partly for sightseeing but also to study the Kemalist experiment in establishing secularism after the collapse of the Ottoman Empire.